

Brother HL-5240

Great print speeds, low memory

The HL-5240 from Brother is a mid-range laser printer oriented towards a medium sized work group. This 28 PPM laser printer looks mean thanks largely to its robust looking design.

The front panel controls consist of two buttons and many LED's for indicating common laser printer errors—out of paper, paper jam, toner empty, etc. The 250-sheet paper cassette is huge and fits flush with the body; paper capacity can be augmented to a massive 800 sheets. The output paper bin holds up to 150 sheets. The manual feeder has a capacity to hold 50 sheets at a time—quite good.

The printer also supports the legacy parallel port, apart from the now de-facto USB; Ethernet is not available as an option, which is strange considering its target audience.

Installing the printer took no time at all; a Flash animation on the CD gives all the details on how to go about installing the printer. It even shows you how to unpack the toner and prep it for usage. For Linux drivers, the CD has a link to Brother's driver repository. The driver

interface is plain but it has all the required features. If you want advanced settings, you will need to look around, though.

Brother claims a 28 PPM speed and it delivered 25 PPM—excellent. The combi-document took 16 seconds to print, since the printer has only 16 MB memory by default. When we tried printing the photo-target disc image file at full resolution (1200 dpi) it automatically reduced the resolution after claiming "memory not enough for full res printing."

Quality was as good as any other printer; the toner density was perfect, as was text sharpness and legibility. Reversed text was printed well and even two-point text was legible. In the grey scale gradation test, banding did occur, but was within acceptable limits. Photographs were not striking, but then that's not what this printer will be used for.



The toner cartridge is priced at Rs 4,590 and is rated to deliver 7000 pages, thus the approximate cost per page works out to just Rs 0.6—excellent. If you have a team of around eight, and don't mind the absence of the network option, the HL-5240 is a good buy, thanks to its very low cost per page.

Specifications

600 dpi print engine, 266 MHz processor, 16 MB memory upgradeable to 528 MB, 250 sheet paper cassette, 9.5 Kg weight, high speed USB and Parallel interface.

Price: 15,500

RATINGS

Features	★★★★○
Print Speed	★★★★★
Print Quality	★★★★★
Value for money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★

Brother HL-5250DN

Low running costs; fast printing

The Brother HL-5250DN comes from the same 52XX series and fixes the shortcomings of its younger sibling the HL-5240. The HL-5250 is the same as the HL-5240, except with duplexing and a network interface.

The HL-5250DN is designed on similar lines as the HL-5240 and borrows all traits, good and bad. The printer is equipped with the standard 250 sheet paper cassette and the capacity can be augmented to 800 sheets via optional paper trays. The manual feed has a 500 sheet capacity but that will be hardly used if an optional tray is fitted. The auto duplexing unit works as expected and allows printing on both sides of the paper.

The HL-5250DN comes with USB, parallel as well as Ethernet interface. Installing the printer via USB was simple

and took very few minutes. However, when installing the printer on a network, some technical expertise of networks is needed. Furthermore, the Web server, while quite extensive and granular, isn't easy to understand for a layman and isn't polished enough. Once

we got with installing the printer on network, however, we were thrilled at the options available for managing the printer.

When it comes to performance, the HL-5250DN is up

to mark. The claimed speed is 28 PPM and the printer delivered 26 PPM—very fast. It can print first page in less than 9 seconds—that's really fast and comparable to the best printers around. The combi-document took 17 seconds; the same lower memory and complexity of the document seem to be the reasons. The photo-target image took 22 seconds—slow, but acceptable.



Quality has no issues: toner density was perfect and spread was minimal. Image printouts weren't striking, and the toner tends to saturate at darker regions in an image.

The cartridge is rated to give 7000 prints and costs Rs 4590, bringing the approximate cost per page to Rs 0.6. The printer is priced at Rs 24,900 and considering its extensive features, manageability, good performance and low running cost the Brother HL-5250 is a good buy.

Specifications

600 dpi, 266 MHz CPU, 32 MB (upgradeable to 544 MB) RAM, 250-sheet paper cassette, duplexing unit and Ethernet interface.

Price: 24,900

RATINGS

Features	★★★★★
Print Speed	★★★★★
Print Quality	★★★★★
Value for money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★

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